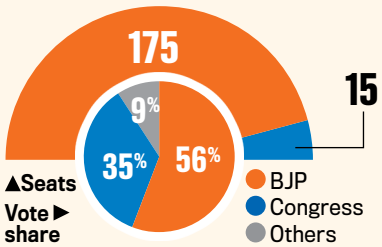
It would take nine months and the arrest of Delhi chief minister and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convenor Arvind Kejriwal to bring together the top leaders of the Opposition parties on a single stage. On March 31, at Delhi's Ramlila Maidan, leaders representing the 27 parties that constitute the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (I.N.D.I.A.) assembled for a mega show of solidarity against the Enforcement Directorate (ED) arresting Kejriwal for his alleged involvement in the Delhi liquor policy case. They also protested the arrest of Hemant Soren, who resigned as Jharkhand chief minister on January 31 after the ED questioned him on an alleged land scam.

But even as its leaders attended the rally, the Congress, the largest party in the Opposition, received a series of notices from the income tax (I-T) department for alleged tax violations, for which it was liable to pay a fine of some Rs 3,500 crore. It was only after the Congress approached the Supreme Court and charged the I-T department with mala fide intention to choke its funds during a crucial election campaign that the tax officials were forced to back down—duly assuring the court that they would not take coercive action

WHY THE CONGRESS MUST DELIVER

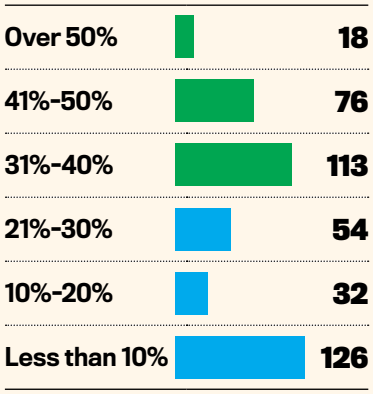
The Grand Old Party is in direct contest with the BJP in nearly 200 seats across 15 states. Here are the key fights that will determine the overall outcome of the election

Seats with a direct face-off between the Congress and the BJP in 2019: **190**



THE SCORING AREAS

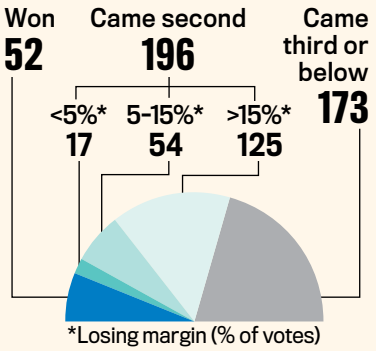
The Congress needs to improve performance in 207 seats where it secured over 30% vote share



Vote share and seats in 2019

THE GAME PLAN

The Congress strategy is to retain what it won of 421 seats contested in 2019 and adding at least 50% of the seats where it stood second with a margin of less than 10 percentage points

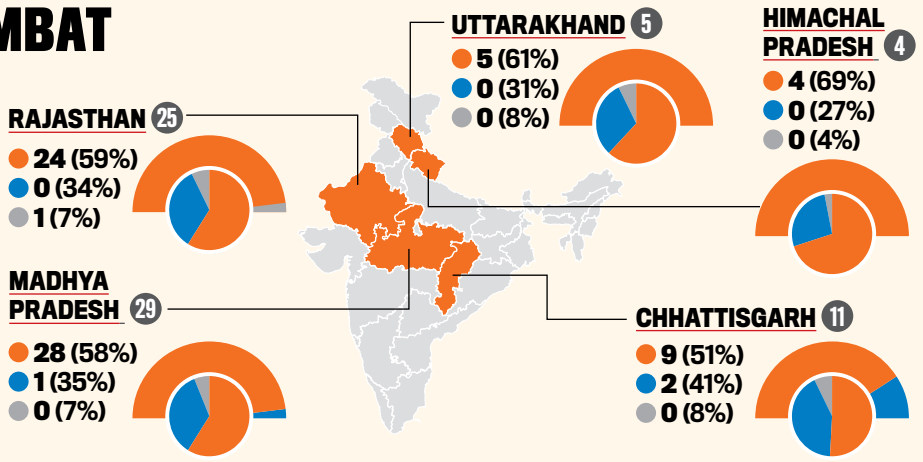


*Losing margin (% of votes)

THE DIRECT COMBAT

In these five states, the Congress is locked in a direct contest with the BJP, which cornered over 50% of the vote share in 2019. Bridging this wide gap is a big challenge

SEATS WON IN LS 2019 (Vote share %)
Total BJP
Congress Others



Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY